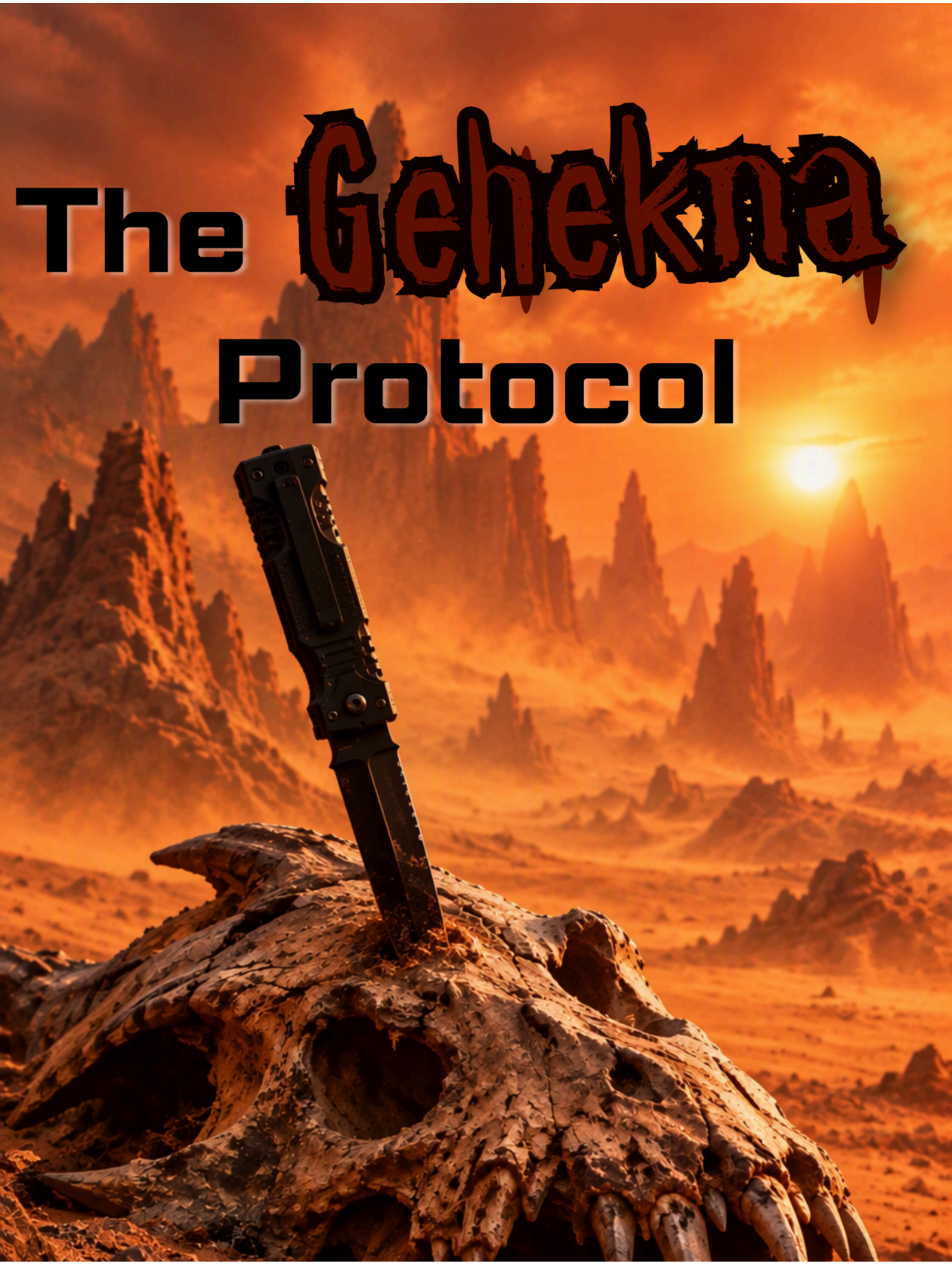
The Gehekna Protocol





Chapter 0

"Gehenna"… that was the name they gave this land. But for the few who had ventured into its depths and returned with their breath still in their lungs, no words could describe it better than "Hell on Earth."

In a world consumed by cruelty, chaos, and madness…

To the far north, a winter so endless it seemed eternal swept death upon anyone who refused to adapt. Jagged mountains and blinding white snow stretched as far as the eye could see. This was the home of 'Auroria,' the Sacred Kingdom of the North——a realm forged by fierce women of unyielding faith.

Further down lay the fertile heart of the world. Lush green plains, life-giving rivers, pristine air, and creatures of all kinds living in apparent harmony. This paradise-like land belonged to the 'Elysium Republic,' the world's greatest superpower, hailed by many as a "Utopia." At least, that was the facade. Behind closed doors, it was a breeding ground for endless war and political strife.

It stood in stark contrast to the 'Zenith Free Zone' in the southeast. A scorched, lawless wasteland where people lived in absolute freedom, yet thrived on cutting-edge technology and a brutal peace maintained by a strict eye-for-an-eye doctrine.

Yet, nothing on Earth could match the cruelty, chaos, and sheer savagery of the deepest south. There lay the 'Gehenna Archipelago'——a massive cluster of islands ringed by towering, razor-sharp cliffs. No one knew how deep these islands went or how many actually existed. It was a realm devoid of human law, mercy, and even the laws of nature. The environment and its mutated beasts shifted constantly, entirely out of control——an unpredictable dead zone.

No one would be mad enough to even approach those lethal waters, if not for one thing: the islands were teeming with rare natural resources and high-value minerals. Treasures desperately coveted by modern science, medicine, and, above all, the military.

But the question remained… who would be reckless and insane enough to set foot in that living hell?

The answer lay not far away. On the very first island, serving as the grim gateway to the Gehenna Archipelago, stood the most dangerous prison in existence: 'The Threshold.' It was a cage for criminals too dangerous to live among society, yet too uniquely talented to be left to rot. Though branded a prison, it functioned as a forward operating base for dead-ender mercenaries——men and women forced to dive into the jaws of Gehenna to harvest its deadly riches.

Chapter 1

Amidst the endless, cold vacuum of the infinite cosmos, a mysterious hand reached out, plucking a constellation shaped like a colossal eye. With a casual flick of a finger, the hand cast it into the void. Instantly, countless stars ignited, swirling and expanding to birth a universe.

Amidst this breathtaking spectacle, a woman’s soft, velvety whisper echoed through the expanse:

"Will you bear it... the power that can change everything?"

Before Cole could answer, the world shattered.

BANG!!!

Cole bolted upright, his forehead colliding violently with the steel frame of the bunk above him.

"*Son of a—! Why couldn’t they build these damn beds a little higher?!*"

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